Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Allen Public Library
300 N. Allen Drive
Allen, TX 75013

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Specialist position at the Allen Public Library. I hold a B.A. from Chapman University, which matches the education your posting describes, and most of what the role involves is work I already do daily: taking materials in, shelving them, keeping a collection orderly, covering a desk, and helping somebody find the thing they came for.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, where I manage the archive of every printed piece we produce. One campaign might be a letter going out to the whole donor file, the next a proposal prepared for a single major donor, the next the invitation set for a conference. I take the samples in from the printer, sort and label them, shelve them by campaign and mail code, keep the shelves accurate, and pull what a writer or a director needs.

The duty I am most drawn to is recommending books, authors and reference material to patrons, and it is the one I have spent the most of my own time on. I founded the Free Knowledge Library, a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum. I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and I built the catalog that readers search. Deciding how a collection should be arranged so that somebody who does not already know what they want can still find their way into it is the whole problem of readers advisory, and I have spent a long time on it. I also developed statetrack.net, a service that publishes state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states, and at work I designed the SQL database behind our archive and the searchable reading room over it, so the whole department can find a past piece on its own.

I am comfortable carrying a desk alone. At Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law I staffed the registrar service window as the front-line contact, handled opening and closing including transaction records, explained procedures that were not obvious, made referrals, and processed more than five hundred transcripts and exam records accurately and in confidence.

Before my current role I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. I worked with a donor on a gift of a complete *Harvard Classics* set, handled it from the first conversation through to the books being on the shelf, gave them a tour of the library, and kept them updated on where the set had been placed. I was also the on-site contact for visitor tours, answering questions about the collections.

The posted schedule, including both weekend afternoons and a Thursday evening, works for me. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I am in Austin now, and I am willing to move anywhere in Texas a position requires.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. Thank you for your consideration, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie